The Election Booth Atlas

Plan of attack: domain names, storage and backups, email, identity and the legal bits

Prepared 8 November 2026. Private working note, not for the repository. Prices are indicative as of writing: check them at the time of purchase.

Principles

- The Atlas is a hobby that may grow. Every choice below is cheap, boring and reversible, and nothing depends on your work computer.
- Three copies of the data on two kinds of media with one off-site: GitHub (code and processed data), a cloud bucket (raw files), and your external drive (everything).
- Nothing public-facing changes before election night on 28 November. Register things now so the names are held; switch the site over in December.
- No business registration is needed while the Atlas earns nothing. The one thing worth doing now is a plain "independent, unaffiliated" line on the site.

1. Domain names

Register **electionboothatlas.org** as the canonical address and **electionboothatlas.com** to redirect to it. .org reads as civic and non-commercial, which is the right signal for an atlas of public data; .com catches people who type it by habit. .au is available only to Australian citizens or residents (the auDA "Australian presence" rule is about the person, not where they live), so take it if you hold citizenship, otherwise skip it.

Registrar: **Cloudflare Registrar**. It sells at wholesale cost (roughly US$10 a year for .com and .org), includes WHOIS privacy, and puts DNS, email forwarding and the storage bucket in the same account, which keeps the whole project on one login. Porkbun or Namecheap are fine alternatives. Avoid GoDaddy-style registrars that upsell and raise renewal prices.

- Create a Cloudflare account with a **personal** email address (never the work one) and turn on two-factor authentication.
- Register .org and .com (and .au if eligible). Turn on auto-renew for each and add a calendar reminder a month before the renewal date anyway: an expired domain is bought by squatters within hours and your old links then point at adverts.
- Leave the site where it is until December. GitHub Pages supports custom domains natively; the switch is four DNS records and one setting (section 7).
- Plan the subdomains now even if unused: **www** (public site), **dark** (EBA Dark behind a login), **data** or **api** (downloads, later).

2. Email

A domain does not come with a mailbox. Two sensible tiers:

- **Now, free:** Cloudflare Email Routing forwards hello@electionboothatlas.org (and any other address) to your personal inbox. You can receive but not send from the address. This is enough for a contact address on the site and for registering social accounts.
- **Later, if you want to send as the Atlas:** a paid mailbox such as Fastmail (about US$5 a month) or Google Workspace (about £5 a month) on the domain. Only worth it once you are corresponding with media or clients.
- Use the new address, not your work or personal one, for every account in this plan, so that the project can be handed over or separated cleanly.

3. Storage and backups

What exists today: the project folder is about 8 GB, of which 4.8 GB is the how-to-vote PDFs and most of the rest is boundary files and census DataPacks. All of that is re-downloadable in principle, but the Wayback captures and the parsed outputs are not, and the PDFs took real effort to collect. The irreplaceable, small things (code, normalised data, site data, captures) are already in Git; the big raw layer needs a home that is not the work laptop.

Copy	What goes there	How it is kept current	Cost
GitHub repository	src/, tools/, live/, data/, site/, README, small raw captures	git push after each session (already the habit)	Free (keep the repo under ~1 GB; large blobs stay gitignored)
Cloud bucket (Cloudflare R2)	raw/ in full: cards, DataPacks, boundaries, scrapes, html caches	rclone sync after each session that adds raw files	10 GB free, then about US$0.015 per GB-month and no egress fees: well under £1 a month for years
External drive	The whole project folder (and ideally Time Machine of the Mac)	rsync when the drive is plugged in; monthly is plenty	Already owned

Why R2 over Backblaze B2 or S3: the pricing is equivalent at this scale (B2 is about US$6 per TB-month), but R2 lives in the same Cloudflare account as the domain and DNS, it never charges to download your own data, and when the Atlas grows to every state the raw layer will still cost pennies. Git LFS is the one option to avoid: GitHub bills bandwidth per gigabyte and it adds nothing over a bucket.

Set-up, once (you run these yourself; keep the keys out of the repository and out of any chat):

- In Cloudflare: R2 → create bucket **eba-raw** (any region; "Automatic" is fine). Create an API token scoped to that bucket with read and write. Note the Account ID.
- On the Mac: **brew install rclone**, then **rclone config** → new remote named **r2**, type S3, provider Cloudflare, paste the access key and secret, endpoint https://<account-id>.r2.cloudflarestorage.com. The config lives in ~/.config/rclone/rclone.conf, outside the project folder.
- Add a one-line script to the project (safe to commit: it holds no secrets):

```
#!/bin/sh
# tools/backup_raw.sh - mirror the raw layer to the bucket; --dry-run first the first time
cd "$HOME/Documents/Election Analyser" && rclone sync raw/ r2:eba-raw/raw --progress --exclu
de ".DS_Store" --exclude "**/__pycache__/**"
```

Restoring onto a fresh machine is the reverse: clone the repository, then **rclone sync r2:eba-raw/raw raw/**, and the pipeline rebuilds everything from there. For the external drive:

```
rsync -a --delete --exclude ".DS_Store" "$HOME/Documents/Election Analyser/" "/Volumes//Elec
tion Analyser/"
```

Do a dry run of each before trusting it (**--dry-run** for rclone, **-n** for rsync), and once a year restore one file from each copy to prove the backups are real.

4. Git hygiene

- Keep gitignoring the big raw directories (raw/htv/, raw/abs/datapacks/, raw/boundaries/abs/) and add raw/vec/*/html/ so the Wayback page caches do not bloat the repo; the parsed districts.json files are small and should stay in.
- Turn on two-factor authentication on GitHub and add a second recovery method.

- Consider creating a free GitHub **organisation** named election-booth-atlas and transferring the repository into it. GitHub redirects the old URL, Pages keeps working, and the project is no longer tied to one personal username, which matters if you ever add a collaborator or hand the site to someone. Optional; no rush.
- Add a LICENSE: MIT (or Apache 2.0) for the code, and a note that the data is derived from the VEC and AEC under their terms (AEC results are CC BY 4.0; VEC material requires attribution). It costs nothing and answers the first question any analyst asks.
- Add a one-page methodology or point the About page at the README: your credibility is the pipeline, so make it easy to find.

5. Business, legal and the "do I need to register anything" question

- **No business registration** is needed in the UK or Australia while the Atlas earns nothing. A hobby website with no income is simply that.
- If paid work ever arrives (a media licence for election night, a consulting engagement), registering as a UK sole trader is a ten-minute HMRC self-assessment form and can be done after the first invoice; an Australian ABN is only for businesses carried on in Australia and is not needed for you. Cross that bridge when a cheque is in sight, not before.
- A trading-name search is still worth five minutes for peace of mind: check "Election Booth Atlas" on the UK IPO trade mark search, IP Australia and ASIC business names. If nothing conflicts, you can use the name freely; registering a trade mark (about £170 in the UK, A$250 per class in Australia) is only worth it if the name becomes an asset.
- Put three lines in the site footer and About: independent and unaffiliated with any party or electoral commission; results from the VEC and AEC, modelling the Atlas's own; no personal data collected (GoatCounter analytics is cookie-free, so no cookie banner is needed). A short disclaimer that projections are estimates covers the election-night page.
- Insurance is unnecessary for a free publication. Revisit only if you sell projections.

6. Identity: name, handles and the look

- Use **electionboothatlas** as the handle everywhere, registered with the new email address: Bluesky, X, Mastodon (aus.social is the natural home for Australian political data people), Instagram, YouTube and the GitHub organisation. Register them even if you post nothing; squatting is cheap and names are not.
- Bluesky lets a domain be the handle: once DNS is in your hands, set @electionboothatlas.org as the account name. It is the single best proof of ownership available and costs nothing.
- Branding can stay simple for a long time: a wordmark (the current masthead already works), a favicon, and one social-preview image (1200 x 630) so links unfurl properly on Bluesky, X and Slack. Add an og:image and description tag to the site when the domain switches.
- Pick one place to announce things (Bluesky, probably) and let the others point to it. Election-analysis Australia lives largely on Bluesky and Mastodon now.

7. The switch itself (December, after election night)

- In the repository, add a file named **CNAME** in the site folder containing exactly: electionboothatlas.org
- In Cloudflare DNS for electionboothatlas.org: four A records for @ pointing at 185.199.108.153, 185.199.109.153, 185.199.110.153 and 185.199.111.153, and a CNAME for www pointing at simonwindley.github.io (or the organisation name if you moved the repo). Set them to "DNS only" (grey cloud) so GitHub can issue the certificate.

- In the repository settings → Pages → Custom domain: enter electionboothatlas.org, wait for the DNS check, then tick Enforce HTTPS.
- For electionboothatlas.com: a Cloudflare redirect rule sending everything to https://electionboothatlas.org/$1 (301).
- Test on a phone off wi-fi, then update the artifact link, the README, the Slack/email signature and the social bios. The old simonwindley.github.io address redirects automatically, so existing links keep working.

8. Costs

Item	Yearly cost (indicative)
electionboothatlas.org and .com at cost (Cloudflare)	about US$20
electionboothatlas.au (if eligible)	about A$15
Cloudflare R2 bucket for ~10 GB of raw data	US$0 to about US$2
Email forwarding (Cloudflare)	US$0
Paid mailbox, only if you need to send as the Atlas	about £60
Hosting (GitHub Pages), social handles, licences	US$0
Total for the first year without a mailbox	under £25

9. Checklist

When	Do
This week (nothing public changes)	Back up: rsync to the external drive. Create the Cloudflare account on a personal email with 2FA; register .org and .com (and .au if eligible) with auto-renew; set up email forwarding for hello@. Register the social handles and the GitHub organisation name. Create the R2 bucket, configure rclone, run the first sync with --dry-run then for real. Add raw/vec/*/html/ to .gitignore. Enable 2FA on GitHub.
Election week	Leave everything alone except the backups.
December	Switch the site to the domain (section 7). Set the Bluesky handle to the domain. Add LICENSE, the footer lines, og:image. Announce.
Later, as needed	Paid mailbox if you start corresponding as the Atlas. GitHub organisation transfer. Trade-mark check. Sole-trader registration only after the first paid work.